



the canoeing/rowing facility at Thousand Island lake, south-west of Shanghai. The Zinjiang Sports Training Base was built with donations from overseas Chinese where the national team strengthened their footwork and movement by practicing in a shallow pool full of quartz sand.

The biggest shift in China's sports philosophy, it can be argued, is not Project 119 but a willingness to hire the best professional coaches for their athletes no matter what the cost. For Beijing, China hired as many as 38 foreign coaches: its women's hockey coach was South Korean, its fencing coach French, its baseball coach was American, its rowing coach Russian.

That Russian Igor Gringko, who was paid \$90,000 a year, said, "Coaches like me help them win gold medals, or we are fired." Forty-four days before the Olympics, Josef Capousek, a German kayaking coach was.

The work ethic of the Chinese athletes trainees has struck home with the coaches, Australian Tom Maher with the Chinese women's basketball team saying the Chinese worked harder than any other athletes he had seen. This is most likely an indirect fallout of the athletes having come through China's unified sports schools system, which, at the last count, totalled 3,000 schools all over the country and four lakh athletes. It is an old-style 1950s communist-style regi-

men, where children are divided into sports on the basis of their physical characteristics: the smaller children go on to become gymnasts and divers, some starting as early as six years, the bigger into taking up sports requiring strength.

China's push behind sport has been both focused and sustained. After its 1984 re-entry into the Olympic movement, the then premier Deng Xiaoping said, "It looks like the impact and influence of sports are so great that they reflect a country's economy and civilisation... we need to improve our sport." That instruction, writes sports historian Xu Guoqi, "immediately became official policy". China's first sports-related law was passed in 1995 and declared that sporting activities should be under the direct control of the state council and that its athletes should be instructed on patriotism, collectivism and socialism.

It is a very heavy load for the young to be hauling around, particularly as the Games came home. Every day in Beijing, there were photos and footage of Chinese weeping—in joy or grief, frustration or relief. The pressure from the state to succeed has extracted a severe cost from young athletes who live away from their homes, spend long hours in training rooms and have little freedom of choice.

Gold medal winning judoka Xian Dongmei saw her baby daughter once in 15 months before the Games, warbling to her over the telephone and seeing her on live Internet video for a few minutes every day. Li Fenglian, doctor for the Chinese national diving team, published a study last year which stated that 26 of 184 divers on the national team had retina damage. Officials told Sun Haiping, coach to star hurdler Liu Xiang, that if Liu failed to win a gold in Beijing, all his previous achievements would become 'meaningless'. After being fired, coach Capousek said, "Chinese sport is like the military, with a big hierarchy. The athlete is the lowest in the hierarchy."



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GIGANTIC: People stand under a large poster of the Olympic Games in Beijing

A SYSTEMATIC PLAN CALLED PROJECT 119 WAS BUILT AROUND THE 119 GOLD MEDALS TO BE WON IN TRACK AND FIELD, SWIMMING, KAYAKING, ROWING AND SAILING.